'Aramis,' said Athos, 'are you jesting?'

'No, no, dear friend; I state only what we all know. You are right; it is not you alone this matter concerns, but my lord and his unworthy servant, myself.'

'Well, then, what do you require besides the general conditions before recited?'

'I require, my lord, that Normandy should be given to Madame de Longueville, with five hundred thousand francs and full absolution. I require that his majesty should deign to be godfather to the child she has just borne; and that my lord, after having been present at the christening, should go to proffer his homage to our Holy Father the Pope.'

'That is, you wish me to lay aside my ministerial functions, to quit France and be an exile.'

'I wish his eminence to become pope on the first opportunity, allowing me then the right of demanding full indulgences for myself and my friends.'

Mazarin made a grimace which was quite indescribable, and then turned to D'Artagnan.

'And you, sir?' he said.

'I, my lord,' answered the Gascon, 'I differ from Monsieur d'Herblay entirely as to the last point, though I agree with him on the first. Far from wishing my lord to quit Paris, I hope he will stay there and continue to be prime minister, as he is a great statesman. I shall try also to help him to down the Fronde, but on one condition—that he sometimes remembers the king's faithful servants and gives the first vacant company of musketeers to a man that I could name. And you, Monsieur du Vallon— '

'Yes, you, sir! Speak, if you please,' said Mazarin.

'As for me,' answered Porthos, 'I wish my lord cardinal, in order to do honour to my house, which gives him an asylum, would in remembrance of this adventure erect my estate into a barony, with a promise to confer that order on one of my particular friends, whenever his majesty next creates peers.'

'You know, sir, that before receiving the order one must submit proofs.'

'My friends will submit them. Besides, should it be necessary, monseigneur will show him how that formality may be avoided.'

Mazarin bit his lips; the blow was direct and he replied rather dryly:

'All this appears to me to be ill conceived, disjointed, gentlemen; for if I satisfy some I shall displease others. If I stay in Paris I cannot go to Rome; if I became pope I could not continue to be prime minister; and it is only by continuing prime minister that I can make Monsieur d'Artagnan a captain and Monsieur du Vallon a baron.'

'True,' said Aramis, 'so, as I am in a minority, I withdraw my proposition, so far as it relates to the voyage to Rome and monseigneur's resignation.'

'I am to remain minister, then?' said Mazarin.

'You remain minister; that is understood,' said D'Artagnan; 'France needs you.'

'And I desist from my pretensions,' said Aramis. 'His eminence will continue to be prime minister and her majesty's favourite, if he will grant to me and my friends what we demand for France and for ourselves.'

'Occupy yourselves with your own affairs, gentlemen, and let France settle matters as she will with me,' resumed Mazarin.

'Ho! ho!' replied Aramis. 'The Frondeurs will have a treaty and your eminence must sign it before us, promising at the same time to obtain the queen's consent to it.'

'I can answer only for myself,' said Mazarin. 'I cannot answer for the queen. Suppose her majesty refuses?'

'Oh!' said D'Artagnan, 'monseigneur knows very well that her majesty refuses him nothing.'

'Here, monseigneur,' said Aramis, 'is the treaty proposed by the deputation of Frondeurs. Will your eminence please read and examine?'

'I am acquainted with it.'

'Sign it, then.'

'Reflect, gentlemen, that a signature given under circumstances like the present might be regarded as extorted by violence.'

'Monseigneur will be at hand to testify that it was freely given.'

'Suppose I refuse?'

'Then,' said D'Artagnan, 'your eminence must expect the consequences of a refusal.'

'Would you dare to touch a cardinal?'

'You have dared, my lord, to imprison her majesty's musketeers.'

'The queen will revenge me, gentlemen.'

'I do not think so, although inclination might lead her to do so, but we shall take your eminence to Paris, and the Parisians will defend us.'

'How uneasy they must be at this moment at Rueil and Saint Germain,' said Aramis. 'How they must be asking, "Where is the cardinal?" "What has become of the minister?" "Where has the favourite gone?" How they must be looking for monseigneur in all corners! What comments must be made; and if the Fronde knows that monseigneur has disappeared, how the Fronde must triumph!'

'It is frightful,' murmured Mazarin.

'Sign the treaty, then, monseigneur,' said Aramis.

'Suppose the queen should refuse to ratify it?'

'Ah! nonsense!' cried D'Artagnan, 'I can manage so that her majesty will receive me well; I know an excellent method.'

'What?'

'I shall take her majesty the letter in which you tell her that the finances are exhausted.'

'And then?' asked Mazarin, turning pale.

'When I see her majesty embarrassed, I shall conduct her to Rueil, make her enter the orangery and show her a certain spring which turns a box.'

'Enough, sir,' muttered the cardinal, 'you have said enough; where is the treaty?'

'Here it is,' replied Aramis. 'Sign, my lord,' and he gave him a pen.

Mazarin arose, walked some moments, thoughtful, but not dejected.

'And when I have signed,' he said, 'what is to be my guarantee?'

'My word of honour, sir,' said Athos.

Mazarin started, turned toward the Comte de la Fère, and looking for an instant at that grand and honest countenance, took the pen.

'It is sufficient, count,' he said, and signed the treaty.

'And now, Monsieur d'Artagnan,' he said, 'prepare to set off for Saint Germain and take a letter from me to the queen.'

''Tis possible; my lord; but before an engagement ensues we shall move your eminence to *another* castle belonging to our friend Du Vallon, who has *three*. We will not expose your eminence to the chances of war.'

'Come,' answered Mazarin, 'I see it will be necessary for me to capitulate.'

'Before a siege?'

'Yes; the conditions will be better than afterward.'

'Ah, my lord! as to conditions, you would soon see how moderate and reasonable we are!'

'Come, now, what are your conditions?'

'Rest yourself first, my lord, and we—we will reflect.'

'I do not need rest, gentlemen; I need to know whether I am among enemies or friends.'

'Friends, my lord! friends!'

'Well, then, tell me at once what you want, that I may see if any arrangement be possible. Speak, Comte de la Fère!'

'My lord,' replied Athos, 'for myself I have nothing to demand. For France, were I to specify my wishes, I should have too much. I beg you to excuse me and propose to the chevalier.'

And Athos, bowing, retired and remained leaning against the mantelpiece, a spectator of the scene.

'Speak, then, chevalier!' said the cardinal. 'What do you want? Nothing ambiguous, if you please. Be clear, short and precise.'

'As for me,' replied Aramis, 'I have in my pocket the very programme of the conditions which the deputation—of which I formed one—went yesterday to Saint Germain to impose on you. Let us consider first the ancient rights. The demands in that programme *must* be granted.'

'We were almost agreed on those,' replied Mazarin; 'let us pass on to private and personal stipulations.'

'You suppose, then, that there *are* some?' said Aramis, smiling.

'I do not suppose that you will all be quite so disinterested as Monsieur de la Fère,' replied the cardinal, bowing to Athos.

'My lord, you are right, and I am glad to see that you do justice to the count at last. The count has a mind above vulgar desires and earthly passions. He is a proud soul—he is a man by himself! You are right—he is worth us all, and we avow it to you!'

Grimaud, in fact, brought back five horses. The nobleman to whom he applied, being a friend of Porthos, was very ready, not to sell them, as was proposed, but to lend them. Ten minutes later the escort stopped at Ermenonville, but the four friends went on with well sustained ardour, guarding Mazarin carefully. At noon they rode into the avenue of Pierrefonds.

'Ah!' said Mousqueton, who had ridden by the side of D'Artagnan without speaking a word on the journey, 'you may think what you will, sir, but I can breathe now for the first time since my departure from Pierrefonds;' and he put his horse to a gallop to announce to the other servants the arrival of Monsieur du Vallon and his friends.

'We are four of us,' said D'Artagnan; 'we must relieve each other in mounting guard over my lord and each of us must watch three hours at a time. Athos is going to examine the castle, which it will be necessary to render impregnable in case of siege; Porthos will see to the provisions and Aramis to the troops of the garrison. That is to say, Athos will be chief engineer, Porthos purveyor-in-general, and Aramis governor of the fortress.'

Meanwhile, they gave up to Mazarin the handsomest room in the château.

'Gentlemen,' he said, when he was in his room, 'you do not expect, I presume, to keep me here a long time *incognito?*'

'No, my lord,' replied the Gascon; 'on the contrary, we think of announcing very soon that we have you here.'

'Then you will be besieged.'

'We expect it.'

'And what shall you do?'

'Defend ourselves. Were the late Cardinal Richelieu alive he would tell you a certain story of the Bastion Saint Gervais, which we four, with our four lackeys and twelve dead men, held out against a whole army.'

'Such feats, sir, are done once—and never repeated.'

'However, nowadays there's no need of so much heroism. To-morrow the army of Paris will be summoned, the day after it will be here! The field of battle, instead, therefore, of being at Saint Denis or at Charenton, will be near Compiègne or Villars-Cotterets.'

'The prince will vanquish you, as he has always done.'

Chapter LXXXVIII

Shows How with Threat and Pen More is Effected than by the Sword

D'Artagnan knew his part well; he was aware that opportunity has a forelock only for him who will take it and he was not a man to let it go by him without seizing it. He soon arranged a prompt and certain manner of travelling, by sending relays of horses to Chantilly, so that he might be in Paris in five or six hours. But before setting out he reflected that for a lad of intelligence and experience he was in a singular predicament, since he was proceeding toward uncertainty and leaving certainty behind him.

'In fact,' he said, as he was about to mount and start on his dangerous mission, 'Athos, for generosity, is a hero of romance; Porthos has an excellent disposition, but is easily influenced; Aramis has a hieroglyphic countenance, always illegible. What will come out of those three elements when I am no longer present to combine them? The deliverance of the cardinal, perhaps. Now, the deliverance of the cardinal would be the ruin of our hopes; and our hopes are thus far the only recompense we have for labours in comparison with which those of Hercules were pygmean.'

He went to find Aramis.

'You, my dear Chevalier d'Herblay,' he said, 'are the Fronde incarnate. Mistrust Athos, therefore, who will not prosecute the affairs of any one, even his own. Mistrust Porthos, especially, who, to please the count whom he regards as God on earth, will assist him in contriving Mazarin's escape, if Mazarin has the wit to weep or play the chivalric.'

Aramis smiled; his smile was at once cunning and resolute.

'Fear nothing,' he said; 'I have my conditions to impose. My private ambition tends only to the profit of him who has justice on his side.'

'Good!' thought D'Artagnan: 'in this direction I am satisfied.' He pressed Aramis's hand and went in search of Porthos.

'Friend,' he said, 'you have worked so hard with me toward building up our fortune, that, at the moment when we are about to reap the fruits of our labours, it would be a ridiculous piece of silliness in you to allow yourself to be controlled by Aramis, whose cunning you know—a cunning which, we may say between ourselves, is not always without egotism; or by Athos, a noble and disinterested man, but *blasé*, who, desiring nothing further for himself, doesn't sympathize with the desires of others. What should you say if either of these two friends proposed to you to let Mazarin go?'

'Why, I should say that we had too much trouble in taking him to let him off so easily.'

'Bravo, Porthos! and you would be right, my friend; for in losing him you would lose your barony, which you have in your grasp, to say nothing of the fact that, were he once out of this, Mazarin would have you hanged.'

'Do you think so?'

'I am sure of it.'

'Then I would kill him rather than let him go.'

'And you would act rightly. There is no question, you understand, provided we secure our own interests, of securing those of the Frondeurs; who, besides, don't understand political matters as we old soldiers do.'

'Never fear, dear friend,' said Porthos. 'I shall see you through the window as you mount your horse; I shall follow you with my eyes as long as you are in sight; then I shall place myself at the cardinal's door—a door with glass windows. I shall see everything, and at the least suspicious sign I shall begin to exterminate.'

'Bravo!' thought D'Artagnan; 'on this side I think the cardinal will be well guarded.' He pressed the hand of the lord of Pierrefonds and went in search of Athos.

'My dear Athos,' he said, 'I am going away. I have only one thing to say to you. You know Anne of Austria; the captivity of Mazarin alone guarantees my life; if you let him go I am a dead man.'

'The count! the count!' cried a young voice that made Athos start.

'Raoul! Raoul!' he ejaculated.

For one moment the young man forgot his habitual respect—he threw himself on his father's neck.

'Look, my lord cardinal,' said Aramis, 'would it not have been a pity to have separated men who love each other as we love? Gentlemen,' he continued, addressing the cavaliers, who became more and more numerous every instant; 'gentlemen, encircle his eminence, that you may show him the greater honour. He will, indeed give us the favour of his company; you will, I hope, be grateful for it; Porthos, do not lose sight of his eminence.'

Aramis then joined Athos and D'Artagnan, who were consulting together.

'Come,' said D'Artagnan, after a conference of five minutes' duration, 'let us begin our journey.'

'Where are we to go?' asked Porthos.

'To your house, dear Porthos, at Pierrefonds; your fine château is worthy of affording its princely hospitality to his eminence; it is, likewise, well situated—neither too near Paris, nor too far from it; we can establish a communication between it and the capital with great facility. Come, my lord, you shall be treated like a prince, as you are.'

'A fallen prince!' exclaimed Mazarin, piteously.

'The chances of war,' said Athos, 'are many, but be assured we shall take no improper advantage of them.'

'No, but we shall make use of them,' said D'Artagnan.

The rest of the night was employed by these cavaliers in travelling with the wonderful rapidity of former days. Mazarin, still sombre and pensive, permitted himself to be dragged along in this way; it looked a race of phantoms. At dawn twelve leagues had been passed without drawing rein; half the escort were exhausted and several horses fell down.

'Horses, nowadays, are not what they were formerly,' observed Porthos; 'everything degenerates.'

'I have sent Grimaud to Dammartin,' said Aramis. 'He is to bring us five fresh horses—one for his eminence, four for us. We, at least, must keep close to monseigneur; the rest of the start will rejoin us later. Once beyond Saint Denis we shall have nothing to fear.'

letter. I placed myself in ambuscade with my sixty men; I encircled the castle; the riding horses I entrusted to Grimaud and I awaited your coming out, which I did not expect till to-morrow, and I didn't hope to free you without a skirmish. You are free to-night, without fighting; so much the better! How did you manage to escape that scoundrel Mazarin? You must have much reason to complain of him.'

'Not very much,' said D'Artagnan.

'Really!'

'I might even say that we have some reason to praise him.'

'Impossible!'

'Yes, really; it is owing to him that we are free.'

'Owing to him?'

'Yes, he had us conducted into the orangery by Monsieur Bernouin, his *valet-de-chambre*, and from there we followed him to visit the Comte de la Fère. Then he offered us our liberty and we accepted it. He even went so far as to show us the way out; he led us to the park wall, which we climbed over without accident, and then we fell in with Grimaud.'

'Well!' exclaimed Aramis, 'this will reconcile me to him; but I wish he were here that I might tell him that I did not believe him capable of so noble an act.'

'My lord,' said D'Artagnan, no longer able to contain himself, 'allow me to introduce to you the Chevalier d'Herblay, who wishes—as you may have heard—to offer his congratulations to your eminence.'

And he retired, discovering Mazarin, who was in great confusion, to the astonished gaze of Aramis.

'Ho! ho!' exclaimed the latter, 'the cardinal! a glorious prize! Halloo! halloo! friends! to horse! to horse!'

Several horsemen ran quickly to him.

'Zounds!' cried Aramis, 'I may have done some good; so, my lord, deign to receive my most respectful homage! I will lay a wager that 'twas that Saint Christopher, Porthos, who performed this feat! Apropos! I forgot— ' and he gave some orders in a low voice to one of the horsemen.

'I think it will be wise to set off,' said D'Artagnan.

'Yes; but I am expecting some one, a friend of Athos.'

'A friend!' exclaimed the count.

'And here he comes, by Jupiter! galloping through the bushes.'

'I needed nothing less than that consideration, my dear D'Artagnan, to persuade myself to adopt the *rôle* of jailer. I give you my word that you will find the cardinal where you leave him.'

'This reassures me more than all the royal signatures,' thought D'Artagnan. 'Now that I have the word of Athos I can set out.'

D'Artagnan started alone on his journey, without other escort than his sword, and with a simple passport from Mazarin to secure his admission to the queen's presence. Six hours after he left Pierrefonds he was at Saint Germain.

The disappearance of Mazarin was not as yet generally known. Anne of Austria was informed of it and concealed her uneasiness from every one. In the chamber of D'Artagnan and Porthos the two soldiers had been found bound and gagged. On recovering the use of their limbs and tongues they could, of course, tell nothing but what they knew—that they had been seized, stripped and bound. But as to what had been done by Porthos and D'Artagnan afterward they were as ignorant as all the inhabitants of the château.

Bernouin alone knew a little more than the others. Bernouin, seeing that his master did not return and hearing the stroke of midnight, had made an examination of the orangery. The first door, barricaded with furniture, had aroused in him certain suspicions, but without communicating his suspicions to any one he had patiently worked his way into the midst of all that confusion. Then he came to the corridor, all the doors of which he found open; so, too, was the door of Athos's chamber and that of the park. From the latter point it was easy to follow tracks on the snow. He saw that these tracks tended toward the wall; on the other side he found similar tracks, then footprints of horses and then signs of a troop of cavalry which had moved away in the direction of Enghien. He could no longer cherish any doubt that the cardinal had been carried off by the three prisoners, since the prisoners had disappeared at the same time; and he had hastened to Saint Germain to warn the queen of that disappearance.

Anne had enforced the utmost secrecy and had disclosed the event to no one except the Prince de Condé, who had sent five or six hundred horsemen into the environs of Saint Germain with orders to bring in

any suspicious person who was going away from Rueil, in whatsoever direction it might be.

Now, since D'Artagnan did not constitute a body of horsemen, since he was alone, since he was not going away from Rueil and was going to Saint Germain, no one paid any attention to him and his journey was not obstructed in any way.

On entering the courtyard of the old château the first person seen by our ambassador was Maître Bernouin in person, who, standing on the threshold, awaited news of his vanished master.

At the sight of D'Artagnan, who entered the courtyard on horseback, Bernouin rubbed his eyes and thought he must be mistaken. But D'Artagnan made a friendly sign to him with his head, dismounted, and throwing his bridle to a lackey who was passing, he approached the *valet-de-chambre* with a smile on his lips.

'Monsieur d'Artagnan!' cried the latter, like a man who has the nightmare and talks in his sleep, 'Monsieur d'Artagnan!'

'Himself, Monsieur Bernouin.'

'And why have you come here?'

'To bring news of Monsieur de Mazarin—the freshest news there is.'

'What has become of him, then?'

'He is as well as you and I.'

'Nothing bad has happened to him, then?'

'Absolutely nothing. He felt the need of making a trip in the Ile de France, and begged us—the Comte de la Fère and Monsieur du Vallon—to accompany him. We were too devoted servants to refuse him a request of that sort. We set out last evening and here we are.'

'Here you are.'

'His eminence had something to communicate to her majesty, something secret and private—a mission that could be confided only to a sure man—and so has sent me to Saint Germain. And therefore, my dear Monsieur Bernouin, if you wish to do what will be pleasing to your master, announce to her majesty that I have come, and tell her with what purpose.'

Whether he spoke seriously or in jest, since it was evident that under existing circumstances D'Artagnan was the only man who could relieve the queen's uneasiness, Bernouin went without hesitation to announce

Chapter LXXXVII

Thinking that Porthos Will Be At Last a Baron, and D'Artagnan a Captain

At the expiration of ten minutes Aramis arrived, accompanied by Grimaud and eight or ten followers. He was excessively delighted and threw himself into his friends' arms.

'You are free, my brothers! free without my aid! and I shall have succeeded in doing nothing for you in spite of all my efforts.'

'Do not be unhappy, dear friend, on that account; if you have done nothing as yet, you will do something soon,' replied Athos.

'I had well concerted my plans,' pursued Aramis; 'the coadjutor gave me sixty men; twenty guard the walls of the park, twenty the road from Rueil to Saint Germain, twenty are dispersed in the woods. Thus I was able, thanks to the strategic disposition of my forces, to intercept two couriers from Mazarin to the queen.'

Mazarin listened intently.

'But,' said D'Artagnan, 'I trust that you honourably sent them back to monsieur le cardinal!'

'Ah, yes!' said Aramis, 'toward him I should be very likely to practice such delicacy of sentiment! In one of the despatches the cardinal declares to the queen that the treasury is empty and that her majesty has no more money. In the other he announces that he is about to transport his prisoners to Melun, since Rueil seemed to him not sufficiently secure. You can understand, dear friend, with what hope I was inspired by that last

The three friends hastened on, but in a short time were obliged to slacken the pace. The cardinal could not keep up with them, though with every wish to do so.

Suddenly D'Artagnan touched something warm, which moved.

'Stop! a horse!' he cried; 'I have found a horse!'

'And I, likewise,' said Athos.

'I, too,' said Porthos, who, faithful to the instructions, still held the cardinal's arm.

'There's luck, my lord! just as you were complaining of being tired and obliged to walk.'

But as he spoke the barrel of a pistol was presented at his breast and these words were pronounced:

'Touch it not!'

'Grimaud!' he cried; 'Grimaud! what art thou about? Why, thou art posted here by Heaven!'

'No, sir,' said the honest servant, 'it was Monsieur Aramis who posted me here to take care of the horses.'

'Is Aramis here?'

'Yes, sir; he has been here since yesterday.'

'What are you doing?'

'On the watch— '

'What! Aramis here?' cried Athos.

'At the lesser gate of the castle; he's posted there.'

'Are you a large party?'

'Sixty.'

'Let him know.'

'This moment, sir.'

And believing that no one could execute the commission better than himself, Grimaud set off at full speed; whilst, enchanted at being all together again, the friends awaited his return.

There was no one in the whole group in a bad humour except Cardinal Mazarin.

to her this strange embassy; and as he had foreseen, the queen gave orders to introduce Monsieur d'Artagnan at once.

D'Artagnan approached the sovereign with every mark of profound respect, and having fallen on his knees presented to her the cardinal's letter

It was, however, merely a letter of introduction. The queen read it, recognised the writing, and, since there were no details in it of what had occurred, asked for particulars. D'Artagnan related everything with that simple and ingenuous air which he knew how to assume on occasions. The queen, as he went on, looked at him with increasing astonishment. She could not comprehend how a man could conceive such an enterprise and still less how he could have the audacity to disclose it to her whose interest and almost duty it was to punish him.

'How, sir!' she cried, as D'Artagnan finished, 'you dare to tell me the details of your crime—to give me an account of your treason!'

'Pardon, madame, but I think that either I have expressed myself badly or your majesty has imperfectly understood me. There is here no question of crime or treason. Monsieur de Mazarin held us in prison, Monsieur du Vallon and myself, because we could not believe that he had sent us to England to quietly look on while they cut off the head of Charles I., brother-in-law of the late king, your husband, the consort of Madame Henrietta, your sister and your guest, and because we did all that we could do to save the life of the royal martyr. We were then convinced, my friend and I, that there was some error of which we were the victims, and that an explanation was called for between his eminence and ourselves. Now, that an explanation may bear fruit, it is necessary that it should be quietly conducted, far from noise and interruption. We have therefore taken away monsieur le cardinal to my friend's château and there we have come to an understanding. Well, madame, it proved to be as we had supposed; there was a mistake. Monsieur de Mazarin had thought that we had rendered service to General Cromwell, instead of King Charles, which would have been a disgrace, rebounding from us to him, and from him to your majesty—a dishonour which would have tainted the royalty of your illustrious son. We were able to prove the contrary, and that proof we are ready to give to your majesty, calling in support of it the august widow weeping in the Louvre, where your royal munificence has provided for her a home. That proof satisfied him so completely that, as a sign of

satisfaction, he has sent me, as your majesty may see, to consider with you what reparation should be made to gentlemen unjustly treated and wrongfully persecuted.'

'I listen to you, and I wonder at you, sir,' said the queen. 'In fact, I have rarely seen such excess of impudence.'

'Your majesty, on your side,' said D'Artagnan, 'is as much mistaken as to our intentions as the Cardinal Mazarin has always been.'

'You are in error, sir,' answered the queen. 'I am so little mistaken that in ten minutes you shall be arrested, and in an hour I shall set off at the head of my army to release my minister.'

'I am sure your majesty will not commit such an act of imprudence, first, because it would be useless and would produce the most disastrous results. Before he could be possibly set free the cardinal would be dead; and indeed, so convinced is he of this, that he entreated me, should I find your majesty disposed to act in this way, to do all I could to induce you to change your resolution.'

'Well, then, I will content myself with arresting you!'

'Madame, the possibility of my arrest has been foreseen, and should I not have returned by to-morrow, at a certain hour the next day the cardinal will be brought to Paris and delivered to the parliament.'

'It is evident, sir, that your position has kept you out of relation to men and affairs; otherwise you would know that since we left Paris monsieur le cardinal has returned thither five or six times; that he has there met De Beaufort, De Bouillon, the coadjutor and D'Elbeuf and that not one of them had any desire to arrest him.'

'Your pardon, madame, I know all that. And therefore my friends will conduct monsieur le cardinal neither to De Beaufort, nor to De Bouillon, nor to the coadjutor, nor to D'Elbeuf. These gentlemen wage war on private account, and in buying them up, by granting them what they wished, monsieur le cardinal has made a good bargain. He will be delivered to the parliament, members of which can, of course, be bought, but even Monsieur de Mazarin is not rich enough to buy the whole body.'

'I think,' returned Anne of Austria, fixing upon him a glance, which in any woman's face would have expressed disdain, but in a queen's, spread terror to those she looked upon, 'nay, I perceive you dare to threaten the mother of your sovereign.'

Mazarin wished to call out, but Porthos held him tight and passed him to D'Artagnan, who seized him by the neck and made him sit down by him; then in a menacing tone, he said:

'Sir! jump directly down, close to Monsieur de la Fère, or, on the honour of a gentleman, I'll kill you!'

'Monsieur, monsieur,' cried Mazarin, 'you are breaking your word to me!'

'I—did I promise you anything, my lord?'

Mazarin groaned.

'You are free,' he said, 'through me; your liberty was my ransom.'

'Agreed; but the ransom of that immense treasure buried under the gallery, to which one descends on pushing a spring hidden in the wall, which causes a tub to turn, revealing a staircase—must not one speak of that a little, my lord?'

'*Diavolo!*' cried Mazarin, almost choked, and clasping his hands; 'I am a lost and ruined man!'

But without listening to his protestations of alarm, D'Artagnan slipped him gently down into the arms of Athos, who stood immovable at the bottom of the wall.

Porthos next made an effort which shook the solid wall, and by the aid of his friend's hand gained the summit.

'I didn't understand it all,' he said, 'but I understand now; how droll it is!'

'You think so? so much the better; but that it may prove laughter-worthy even to the end, let us not lose time.' And he jumped off the wall.

Porthos did the same.

'Attend to monsieur le cardinal, gentlemen,' said D'Artagnan; 'for myself, I will reconnoitre.'

The Gascon then drew his sword and marched as *avant* guard.

'My lord,' he said, 'which way do we go? Think well of your reply, for should your eminence be mistaken, there might ensue most grave results for all of us.'

'Along the wall, sir,' said Mazarin, 'there will be no danger of losing yourselves.'

'You are mistaken. Monsieur du Vallon and I are the only two who are armed. The count is not; and should we meet with one of your patrol we must defend ourselves.'

''Tis true.'

'Where can we find another sword?' asked Porthos.

'My lord,' said D'Artagnan, 'will lend his, which is of no use to him, to the Comte de la Fère.'

'Willingly,' said the cardinal; 'I will even ask the count to keep it for my sake.'

'I promise you, my lord, never to part with it,' replied Athos.

'Well, well,' cried D'Artagnan, 'this reconciliation is truly touching; have you not tears in your eyes, Porthos?'

'Yes,' said Porthos; 'but I do not know if it is feeling or the wind that makes me weep; I think it is the wind.'

'Now climb up, Athos, quickly,' said D'Artagnan. Athos, assisted by Porthos, who lifted him up like a feather, arrived at the top.

'Now, jump down, Athos.'

Athos jumped and disappeared on the other side of the wall.

'Are you on the ground?' asked D'Artagnan.

'Yes.'

'Without accident?'

'Perfectly safe and sound.'

'Porthos, whilst I get up, watch the cardinal. No, I don't want your help, watch the cardinal.'

'I am watching,' said Porthos. 'Well?'

'You are right; it is more difficult than I thought. Lend me your back—but don't let the cardinal go.'

Porthos lent him his back and D'Artagnan was soon on the summit of the wall, where he seated himself.

Mazarin pretended to laugh.

'Are you there?' asked Porthos.

'Yes, my friend; and now— '

'Now, what?' asked Porthos.

'Now give me the cardinal up here; if he makes any noise stifle him.'

'Madame,' replied D'Artagnan, 'I threaten simply and solely because I am obliged to do so. Believe me, madame, as true a thing as it is that a heart beats in this bosom—a heart devoted to you—believe that you have been the idol of our lives; that we have, as you well know—good Heaven!—risked our lives twenty times for your majesty. Have you, then, madame, no compassion for your servants who for twenty years have vegetated in obscurity, without betraying in a single sigh the solemn and sacred secrets they have had the honour to share with you? Look at me, madame—at me, whom you accuse of speaking loud and threateningly. What am I? A poor officer, without fortune, without protection, without a future, unless the eye of my queen, which I have sought so long, rests on me for a moment. Look at the Comte de la Fère, a type of nobility, a flower of chivalry. He has taken part against his queen, or rather, against her minister. He has not been unreasonably exacting, it seems to me. Look at Monsieur du Vallon, that faithful soul, that arm of steel, who for twenty years has awaited the word from your lips which will make him in rank what he is in sentiment and in courage. Consider, in short, your people who love you and who yet are famished, who have no other wish than to bless you, and who, nevertheless—no, I am wrong, your subjects, madame, will never curse you; say one word to them and all will be ended—peace succeed war, joy tears, and happiness to misfortune!'

Anne of Austria looked with wonderment on the warlike countenance of D'Artagnan, which betrayed a singular expression of deep feeling.

'Why did you not say all this before you took action, sir?' she said.

'Because, madame, it was necessary to prove to your majesty one thing of which you doubted—-that is, that we still possess amongst us some valour and are worthy of some consideration at your hands.'

'And that valour would shrink from no undertaking, according to what I see.'

'It has hesitated at nothing in the past; why, then, should it be less daring in the future?'

'Then, in case of my refusal, this valour, should a struggle occur, will even go the length of carrying me off in the midst of my court, to deliver me into the hands of the Fronde, as you propose to deliver my minister?'

'We have not thought about it *yet*, madame,' answered D'Artagnan, with that Gascon effrontery which had in him the appearance of *naïveté;* 'but if we four had resolved upon it we should do it most certainly.'

'I ought,' muttered Anne to herself, 'by this time to remember that these men are giants.'

'Alas, madame!' exclaimed D'Artagnan, 'this proves to me that not till to-day has your majesty had a just idea of us.'

'Perhaps,' said Anne; 'but that idea, if at last I have it— '

'Your majesty will do us justice. In doing us justice you will no longer treat us as men of vulgar stamp. You will see in me an ambassador worthy of the high interests he is authorized to discuss with his sovereign.'

'Where is the treaty?'

'Here it is.'

Anne of Austria cast her eyes upon the treaty that D'Artagnan presented to her.

'I do not see here,' she said, 'anything but general conditions; the interests of the Prince de Conti or of the Ducs de Beaufort, de Bouillon and d'Elbeuf and of the coadjutor, are herein consulted; but with regard to yours?'

'We do ourselves justice, madame, even in assuming the high position that we have. We do not think ourselves worthy to stand near such great names.'

'But you, I presume, have decided to assert your pretensions *viva voce?*'

'I believe you, madame, to be a great and powerful queen, and that it will be unworthy of your power and greatness if you do not recompense the arms which will bring back his eminence to Saint Germain.'

'It is my intention so to do; come, let us hear you. Speak.'

'He who has negotiated these matters (forgive me if I begin by speaking of myself, but I must claim that importance which has been given to me, not assumed by me) he who has arranged matters for the return of the cardinal, ought, it appears to me, in order that his reward may not be unworthy of your majesty, to be made commandant of the guards—an appointment something like that of captain of the musketeers.'

''Tis the appointment Monsieur de Tréville held, you ask of me.'

'The place, madame, is vacant, and although 'tis a year since Monsieur de Tréville has left it, it has not been filled.'

'Let us see,' said D'Artagnan.

'In the first place, do you accept?' asked the cardinal.

'Unfold your plan, my lord, and we will see.'

'Take notice that you are shut up—captured.'

'You well know, my lord, that there always remains to us a last resource.'

'What?'

'That of dying together.'

Mazarin shuddered.

'Listen,' he said; 'at the end of yonder corridor is a door, of which I have the key, it leads into the park. Go, and take this key with you; you are active, vigorous, and you have arms. At a hundred steps, on turning to the left, you will find the wall of the park; get over it, and in three leaps you will be on the road and free.'

'Ah! by Jove, my lord,' said D'Artagnan, 'you have well said, but these are only words. Where is the key you speak of?'

'Here it is.'

'Ah, my lord! You will conduct us yourself, then, to that door?'

'Very willingly, if it be necessary to reassure you,' answered the minister, and Mazarin, who was delighted to get off so cheaply, led the way, in high spirits, to the corridor and opened the door.

It led into the park, as the three fugitives perceived by the night breeze which rushed into the corridor and blew the wind into their faces.

'The devil!' exclaimed the Gascon, ''tis a dreadful night, my lord. We don't know the locality, and shall never find the wall. Since your eminence has come so far, come a few steps further; conduct us, my lord, to the wall.'

'Be it so,' replied the cardinal; and walking in a straight line he went to the wall, at the foot of which they all four arrived at the same instant.

'Are you satisfied, gentlemen?' asked Mazarin.

'I think so, indeed; we should be hard to please if we were not. Deuce take it! three poor gentlemen escorted by a prince of the church! Ah! apropos, my lord! you remarked that we were all active, vigorous and armed.'

'Yes.'